

Mash 'em up

We got tired of looking at different sites each day, so we brought all of them together

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Mash-ups seem to be the latest fad in the crazy world of Web 2.0—people don't want to go all over the Internet for their daily stuff; they want it in one place. Mash-ups are also increasingly used by businesses to manage data and information on their sites. If you thought a mash-up needed a large team to develop and maintain, you couldn't be farther from the truth. With a little patience and a clear head, you can build a mash-up in a jiffy.

You'll need a Web site of your own. You could also create a mash-up on your iGoogle page or use a site like Netvibes (www.netvibes.com). IBM has a QEDWiki for primarily business users, while Microsoft's Popfly lets you build a stunning mash-up on its SilverLight platform. We'll go with a Blogger page (www.blogger.com)—most people have a blog of their own now, and Blogger's new Customize feature has layout elements for a wide variety of sources like HTML / JavaScript, RSS feeds, pictures, videos and more. No more editing HTML—just drag and drop!

Getting Started

We start with a blank Blogger page (you should be logged in to Blogger). Choose a template with a wide sidebar—you don't want your apps to spill over the boundary of the page. The Customize link at the top right will take you to the Edit Layout page—click on Add a Page Element and you'll get a pop-up with options to add polls, pictures, HTML/JavaScript, feeds, logos, a video bar, and more. You can edit the HTML of the page—or do it the easier way.

Choose from Google Gadgets (www.google.com/ig/directory?synd=open)—they have an astonishing variety of gadgets tailored for almost everything. Inserting them into your page is simple enough—copy a line of HTML and paste it in Blogger's element holder for HTML / JavaScript. Many of these Gadgets—especially those with eye candy—need Flash to work; install the free Flash player from www.adobe.com/products/flashplayer/ if you don't have it.

The First Gadget

Adding social networking sites—especially Facebook and Orkut—to your blog is now a breeze. If you're a Facebook junkie, this is for you—a search on the directory will bring up Facebook apps

that let you check your account from within your Blogger page. Select the gadget and click on Add to your webpage. You'll get a snapshot of your gadget, with some minor settings like size adjustments and colour schemes. Play around with them till you're satisfied. Other settings are specific to the gadget—in this case, you have options for what to keep in your Facebook gadget.

Tip: Drag the bottom right corner of the preview above to resize the gadget.

Display settings	Gadget settings
Title: Facebook	Picture: ☒
Width: 320 px	Status: ☒
Height: 200 px	Requests: ☒
Border:	Invites: ☒
	Messages: ☒
	Wall Posts: ☒
	Pokes: ☒
	Events: ☒
	Search box: ☒
	Auto-Refresh: ☐ Only when I refresh the page

The settings for a typical Google Gadget

Once you've made your choice, click on Get the Code at the bottom. A line of HTML code appears, which you copy and paste into the HTML / JavaScript element holder. Simple.

More Gadgets

After putting in the first gadget, you should be raring to go. For the rest, here are our recommendations:

Orkut: Access to Orkut is quite easy from your page, especially a Google



Get Orkut on your page

site like Blogger. There are no sign-in hassles, and your Orkut profile with full-blown functionality is enabled with this nifty gadget.

IM: Access to IMs (Gtalk, Yahoo! Messenger, MSN Messenger, and more) is quite easy with gadgets available. The Yahoo! Messenger gadget is nothing special, but Google Talk was like the real thing. Tabbed conversations, smileys, the

